

“HUZN”

CHAPTER 1

You could see the earth trembling it's crust shifting, the grains and mudstones toppled over each other, the crumbs scattered around the crevice as if something was lurching, trying to spring up from the ground to flourish into a new life and it finally did... an ant sprouting from the ground like a green shoot making its way out of the earth it crept in an unruly manner trying to balance itself with the uneven coarse earth it slowly crept forward toppling pieces of the ground before settling on a gait suitable for the terrain, finally coming to a halt at black sole burrowed into the very ground, the fresh unearthed soil, dark and rich as if blood had seeped through the earth itself giving it texture and color, trying to ladder up to this obstruction in its course, for a moment's notice the ant became unseen merged with the black striations in the sole, unfettered the sunken sole was ever so still, not even writhing a hint of the soil.

Unable to overcome this novel hurdle, it leapt down, delineating back on its steps found its way back to whence it once rose out of. As it stood atop the small anthill stagnant it seemed to sense an imminent change, erratically it dove down becoming one with the earth once again. The anthill grew next to a grave with a fragments of granite surrounding it like broken unattended lives and weeds sprouting within the thin bladed overgrown grass, the grave was fenced by metal, marked with spots of rust like an abundance of rotted flesh on a corpse.

The flowers were awfully dull, bleached even drained of their vibrancy, was it because of the dismal weather or was it that they longed for the warmth of a human touch, the gloomy grey silhouette was barely enough to create a contrast in the colors. You could smell a faint and dying scent of incense lit somewhere nearby. Given the

time of the year one would long for this weather every day, but today wasn't like the others, downpour seemed inevitable all the little hints in the air were evident of torrential rain, the overcast of harrowing black clouds, the ever so slight presence of light barely enough to illuminate the silhouette and usual roars, yet something seemed to fill the air that defied the laws of nature intervening in its power. This strange sensation that stemmed from the man covered in black seemed to shroud the atmosphere around him was "life" or rather the scarcity of it.

At first his lips barely moved almost instinctively as if he wanted to say something to break the silence, finally a voice was drawn audible enough for his own ears, "Bure Log". Not an ounce of life was behind those words.

CHAPTER 2:

He noticed that the lines in the headstone still ran deep, a testament of timeless craftsmanship of the mason, the intricate lines with beautiful vines and petals at their ends bordering the headstone of soothing and lively green were almost gone now, faded revealing the bare carved body of the white marble. Fleeting time had carefully scraped off the color leaving behind a weathered spots of futility and forlorn hopes.

The engraving on the headstone designating the last resting place of the dear departed were still delineated they once ran with rich blood crimson and now they were as dull as a shade of brick, a sad remnant of its long gone beauty. The name was barely legible now known only by a few mouths that came to know him. The thought of the painstaking task of revitalizing the headstone had crossed his mind many a times but he could never find the fine paint brush that he

needed to get the job done or maybe it was that he trusted his hands no longer.

He chose to offer his prayers solemnly his words became lost in the winds as he continued to pray two women noticed the man crouched besides the grave but he paid no heed to them, as he said his vows in silence he tried getting back up grabbing the metal bars of the grave next to him as reached for them his hand slipped nicking his ring finger he instinctively braced for impact with his other hand and it landed right on top the anthill depressing it into the ground but never noticed the pain running through his nerves or reacted to it now he firmly grasped the bars again staining his palm with a meld of rust and flakes of dried scraped paint and got up in an orderly fashion.

He slipped a small handbook in his coat pocket and turned his back to the grave amidst his motion a single drop of water landed on his right shoulder like a hammer striking the cold anvil he felt the drop punch a sense of clarity in him and went to brush it off and it was now that he saw he had stained his coat with blood as he saw the red leaving his fingertip he felt the sensation now of his inconvenience but he carried on as if untouched by it. He was too lost in the weight of his mind trying to recollect his shattered obtrusive thoughts and fragments of cherished memories. As he walked a drop became two, two became four and as was closing to the graveyards gate his coat had changed color from silver to a warm grey.

He never realized when his legs gave up he slammed the mire filled ground with a heavy thud planting his face in the earth when a few splashes of mud flew around, he lay there completely still for a moment or two as he felt the drops hitting his bare neck and the droplets like the gentle caress of woman's hands trickling down his spine and face.

Picking himself up the ground with his hands he turned to a side and lay on his back proceeding into a luxurious sprawl it felt warm for some reason as the rain dissolved off the earths stains like unresolved regrets off his face as if the sky itself had sought to erase the burden off his past.

His picked his head up and traced the two veiled women with his hollow eyes as they hurried past him he mustered what strength was left in him to pick himself back up brushed off what mud and filth he could off his clothes and carried himself to the bus stand nearby. He took a left only to meet eyes with the same women whom he encountered a few minutes ago. He buried his face deep in his chest with his hands closing off his ears only to be alerted by the shouts of the bus conductor a few moments later. He climbed the steps with the weight of souls of entire graveyard resting on his body, taking a seat besides the door on a window seat he shut himself off and never noticed the piercing eyes of judgement that held him accountable or maybe he never wanted to notice them.

CHAPTER 3:

He survived the ride back home soaked with uncertainty that even he felt would end badly, damned with deviancy and ambiguity he just didn't know what could happen the very next second, climbing the stairs he turned left to reach he was finally facing the door that held so much room for love, reaching for his keys to open the door and felt the wet crumbled note that he was supposed to buy batteries for the water heater, he pulled out his keys and with trial and error finally managed to open the door, Hiba upon hearing the door creak left the warmth of the kitchen to go to the narrow passage dividing their home, she only noticed the muddy boot trails left on the floor first as she slowly followed the trail on her right she

saw a man that for the love of her life could not recognize to be her husband.

Her steps were small full of daze and unease her gait unsteady, as she was reaching close to him a sense of overwhelming despair and fear took over her mind, "Ta..Tasay? is that r-really you?" the words burdened by the overbearing weight of grief and upheaval glided out from her lips through the rarefied air with care and gentleness as if someone was dipping a pen into ink and drawing it out with indulgence ever so thoughtfully. A hideous variety of unrest and then peace reflected off her face as recognized the mole on his right ear lobe like a stain on a beautiful and fragile canvas. "It is you, what happened to you, what happe.. what is all this I called for you so many times but you never answered", tears began rolling from her elegant eyes. She sniffed up her tears and wiped away her watery eyes and quickly gathered herself. She pulled away the filth ridden overcoat gently not over pulling on the arms in that moment she felt as she was peeling off the garments of still lifeless mannequin awaiting the strings to be attached so it can brought back to life. Leaping through the glass door dividing the kitchen and living room she back to the kitchen she grabbed a kettle of warm water that she was preparing for tea and handful of paper towels and came back to Tasay. She started by carefully cleaning off the scum gently wiping it away with warm water and towels when she noticed streaks of red on the paper towels and then she saw the broken bone splitting his nose into two at his nostrils she was moved aback at first she let out a whimper losing her breath, "TASAYY" her voice breaking off in the end almost as if someone had strung out the words from her dry and barren throat like a chipped blunt blade being forced out from a boulder, she stumbled on her feet but quickly got back up, Tasay did not feel the need to help her out.

She was slowly peeling off the scabs of dried dulled blood mixed with mud her a tremor overtook her gentle hands she started

sobbing but she still wanted to help Tasay with each stroke of her careful hands she was losing control.

She clenched her hair pulling out some patches of hair she was now running all over the living room she was very squeamish each time she looked at him her wails raised in volume she couldn't look at Tasays face anymore she was practically screaming now until it all felt silent when she slipped and hit her head on the glass top of the centre table, Tasay now watching it all with a cold commanding sneer.

Her eyes slowly opened when the hysterical laughter started to pierce her ears, she picked herself up, on her left there he sat, she asked how he was but the words meant nothing now, for now it would be her last words...

CHAPTER 4:

Nothing was out of the ordinary this morning, the weather was a bit warm a little humid. Tasay woke up to the light glimmers of sunshine peeking through the drapes gently lightening up his eyes, his droopy eyes glanced over the wall clock and saw it was ten past nine making him too late for comfort, he pulled off the bedspread with urgency, he quickly washed his face and got rid of his annoying morning breath. His breakfast today like usual was a glass of cold milk which he enjoyed without any sugar or additives, accompanying the milk were a few broken pieces of biscuits neatly wrapped in their packaging still set on the table top. On this fateful morning Tasay was praying that Nakeeb and Shumaila would pull their own weight in this week's crucial presentation. He changed into the sleek navy pants with a black button up that he bought two days ago and put a fine black woven blazer still feeling something was off he looked at grey sneakers which he forgot to clean that he stained the day

before while coming back home. He devised today's course of action but he never anticipated the lint forming on his blazer sleeves. All of his meticulous efforts of trying to remove some it were in vain as he ended up ruining the blazer cuffs altogether. Frustrated he just bit off the few loose ends and called it a day making a mental note to go the tailor on his way back home from the university to get his blazer darned which he would eventually forget. The ringing phone made him even more vexed the last thing he wanted to start off this lovely morning was ill fate. On the other end was Nakeeb. Nakeeb hated to be the bearer of the bad news but he was calling him to inform that he won't be able to reach on their set time due to unforeseen circumstances but fortunately it ended up being just right as he ended up being on time actually. As he was putting down the phone Tasay noticed a text and opened to Shumaila's message that she can't show up early as the three of them had planned yesterday. Tch... he let out a sigh of disbelief but quickly gathered his everyday carry to be on his way as he didn't want to be any more late he was hoping that by some miracle today would come to pass with ease and triumph.

The fateful first encounter was prosaic, Tasay while getting off the bike with his phone to his face tucked in his right shoulder and his bag in his left hand was in urgency almost if a matter of life and death, he tripped on a small ledge dividing the stairs to ground he heard the laptop break in his face on his knees as he gathering everything. Out of the corner of his eye, he noticed a hand appear, offering him the scattered papers. His gaze was drawn briefly to the delicate silver chain of her watch—an unremarkable detail that somehow felt significant, like an anchor pulling his attention back to the present moment.

Raising his eyes he saw her for the first like a valkyrie descending down from Valhalla to rescue him from the grievances. Their eyes locked for a moment but she broke the unbroken silence by handing

him all the papers she had picked up and left to be on her way. Tasay awestruck and tongue tied gazed as she climbed up the stairs. In that moment his heart was ablaze he could hear his own heartbeat and listen to his own thoughts his whole world seemed to be in upheaval.

He felt the hand strike his neck across like a whip waking him from a slumber of love, he turned around to see Nakeeb's smiling face as he hugged him, as they both went in Tasay wondered why he couldn't hear a word Nakeeb had said to him earlier. His mind kept drifting back to the soft fabric of her sky-blue shirt, the playful pink dots catching the light, and the rhythm of her steps. For a moment, he wondered why something so fleeting could hold his attention so tightly. He could almost hear the sound of her footsteps still, like a memory lingering just out of reach. It was an odd feeling, like having heard a beautiful song and being unable to recall its melody, but knowing it's something important. Her plump lips and her deep brown eyes, no matter what he did this fixated image of her wouldn't leave his mind or was it that he never erase her memory from the canvas of mind, Nakeeb at this point was dragging Tasay to the lawn.

Tasay always admired Shumaila and was both pleased and shocked to see her with 3 cups of coffee for the 3 of them.

As the discussion continued about the presentation's, Tasay's mind wandered once again. He was aware of the words being exchanged, the pragmatic discussions of timing, slides, and transitions, but they felt distant, like background noise to the hum of his thoughts. He had always prided himself on being meticulous in these moments, but now everything seemed secondary to the image of her.

Taking God's graceful name he entered.

After half an hour the 3 of them were called upon to present, it was agreed upon that Nakeeb would start by introducing the 3 of them individually where each of them would briefly say something about

themselves and then continue to the next person but of course Tasay never listened.

“To my right is Tassayar Bin Waris” as he heard “Waris” he raised his head in profound confusion he stammered for a moment, but luckily Nakeeb took action and saved the day. He received a stern eye from Nakeeb as Shumaila was saying the words. In that moment Tasay left the stage for a quick water break, he had now realized the significance of the moment but still could not clear his mind of her, He stood at the sink, letting the cold water sharpen his focus, a brief but much-needed reset. When he returned to the stage, he wasn’t thinking about her or the disarray in his mind. He was thinking about the work, the presentation, and the people who had come to hear them. He felt a quiet confidence settle into him—not the loud kind, but the kind that comes with taking things one step at a time, regardless of the distractions, he received a look of appreciation and of confidence from Nakeeb.

At the end they received a standing ovation, they were greeted by the guest of honor.

CHAPTER 5:

He breezed through the university grounds like winds piercing the tree line, his head down and his mind focused only her his focus only interrupted when he bumped into another girl taking the same path as him but that didn’t stop him rather he hurried towards the gate wanting to go back home as soon as he possibly could.

He took the bus back home, his backpack clutched tightly in his hands nothing seemed to mind him, running up the stairs he opened the door as soon as could slamming it shut behind him, out of breath he slid on the door and lay there with his back to the door, he lay there for a while with his eyes locked on the bare wall of the empty living room.

The sound of his phone ringing scared him and it was Nakeeb calling he ignored the call and when straight to his bed

He fell on his bed he felt as if he was burying himself in the bed and he let himself sink, he couldn't care about anything else right now

Chapter 5 to be continued

CHAPTER 6:

The next day wasn't so different either, he woke up got ready but he forgot to take the glass of cold milk and didn't seem to even remember how or why nothing really seemed to matter right now, not that he was already late, not that he had forgot to get the printouts for their project or the fact that he again wore the same gray sneakers that were stained. Nothing seemed to matter he just wanted to get to the university as soon as possible. He just wanted to be on the same set of stairs as yesterday where he first met her by fate.

Franticly his eyes gleaming with the bliss of hope began to run up and down the stairs yearning to catch even a glance of the blue and pink that he drowned in since yesterday, but his eyes sank to the bottom of his feet when the sense of forlorn hope finally overwhelmed his ignorant bliss, bested by the uncertainty of life he began to climb the stairs leaving behind his hopes and fears,

